

PU'ER TEA

Pu'er, or dark tea, is the only tea that contains probiotics, or "good" microbes. It can be aged for many years, and increases in value accordingly.

This tea is most commonly available in cake or brick form, but is also available as loose leaves, sometimes aged in bamboo. If you're using pressed Pu'er, try not to break the leaves when prying them from the cake, as this will damage them, making the tea bitter. Look for production dates on the wrapper. Pu'er continues to ripen and age over time, so can be kept for many years and tasted each year to experience the developing flavors.

PREPARATION GUIDELINES

Tea shown here: Shou Pu'er cake, 2010, from Yongde County, Yunnan province, China

Measure: 1 tsp for $\frac{3}{4}$ cup water

Water temperature: 200°F (95°C)

Infusion: Rinse with hot water first, to soften the leaves for steeping, then steep for 2 minutes. Increase steeping time for 1 minute for each infusion. Can be used for 3–4 infusions.



WET LEAVES

After steeping, the whole leaves may vary from green to brown to black.



LIQUOR

This rich, opaque dark brown or purple brew tastes of leather, and dark, dried cherries.



DRY LEAVES

Pu'er in cake form has long, medium to dark brown and, sometimes, green leaves pressed into shape.